5

HINDUISM AND THE POLITICS OF HINDUTVA

When I was a columnist for *The Hindu*, which despite its name has been a secular, even left-inclined, newspaper throughout its existence, I received a number of letters from readers on the subject of Hindu ethics and *dharma*, prompted by some of my writings on the subject. One letter, from the retired Director-General of Police of Tripura State, Mr B. J. K. Tampi, made a challenging point. Arguing that *dharma* 'has a pre-eminently secular meaning of social ethics covering law-abiding conduct,' Mr Tampi sought for *dharma* its due prominence in Hindu life. 'In fact the four ends of human life,' he went on, 'dharma, artha, kama and moksha, are always mentioned in that order. The purport is that the pursuit of wealth and pleasure should be within the parameters of dharma and moksha (the final emancipation of the soul from rebirth through religious practices).' Mr Tampi adds, citing Swami Ranganathananda (1908–2005, the spiritual teacher who was the thirteenth and most famous head of the Ramakrishna Mission): 'the excessive Indian fear of rebirth has led to the neglect of true worldly dharma for the sake of an other-worldly moksha. It has made men unfit both in the worldly (secular) and spiritual spheres.'

Now I have never met the good Mr Tampi—whose theological learning is all the more impressive in one who served in the practical profession of a policeman—but his analysis gladdens my secular heart. The fact is that, despite having done so much to attract the opprobrium of those who seek to politicise Hinduism, or the Hindutva brigade as I call them, I do believe that propagating *dharma*—and instilling deeply at all levels of society the need to live according to one's *dharma*—can be the key to bridging the present gap between the religious and the secular in India.

The social scientist T. N. Madan has argued that the increasing secularisation of modern Indian life is responsible for the rise of fundamentalism, since 'it is the marginalisation of faith, which is what